

Watchmaker or Vegetable? Hume's Dialogues and the Argument from Design

An original lesson plan inspired by **David Hume's** *Dialogues Concerning Natural Religion* (Project Gutenberg). Not affiliated with or endorsed by Project Gutenberg or David Hume. Explore the original course: <https://www.gutenberg.org/ebooks/4583>

GRADE LEVEL

Grades 11-12 / Intro College

DURATION

65 minutes

TOPICS

Philosophy of Religion

“Does the order and apparent design we see in nature really give us good evidence for an intelligent designer — or does the analogy break down the moment we examine it closely?”

Learning Objectives

By the end of this lesson, students will be able to:

- Explain the argument from design as voiced by Cleanthes and summarize Philo's central objections to the analogy between the universe and a designed artifact.
- Apply Hume's own standards for evaluating analogical reasoning to the world-versus-machine comparison, identifying where the analogy grows weaker under scrutiny.
- Evaluate the ambiguous ending of Part XII and construct a textually-supported argument for which character's position the dialogue ultimately favors.

Materials Needed

- Short excerpted passages from Parts II, V, and XII of the *Dialogues* (public-domain Gutenberg edition, pre-selected and printed)
- Character role cards for Cleanthes, Philo, and Demea
- Whiteboard for tracking objections raised against the design argument as they emerge
- Sticky notes for text annotation during small-group reading

Lesson Procedure

Hook: The Watch on the Heath

8 min

Present the classic image of finding an intricate watch lying on an empty heath and ask what students would infer about its origin, and why. Then ask them to extend the same reasoning to the universe itself — does a complex, ordered world license the same inference to a designer that a watch does?

Direct Instruction: Meeting the Three Voices

12 min

Introduce Hume's dialogue form and its three characters: Cleanthes (a "reasonable" natural theology built on the design analogy), Demea (an orthodox theist skeptical of reasoning about God at all, favoring revelation and humility), and Philo (the probing skeptic, often read as closest to Hume's own voice, who relentlessly tests Cleanthes's analogy).

Small-Group Close Reading

20 min

Assign each group one of Philo's objections from Part V — for example, that the world resembles a self-generating organism or vegetable as much as a designed machine, or that visible imperfections in the world (waste, suffering) suggest an imperfect or even plural set of causes rather than one perfect designer. Groups restate their assigned objection in their own words and apply it to a modern example of "apparent design," such as the fine-tuning of physical constants or evolutionary adaptation.

Whole-Class Discussion: The Part XII Puzzle

18 min

Groups share their objections and modern examples. Then turn to Philo's surprising concession in Part XII that there is some "remote analogy" pointing to intelligence in nature, and Cleanthes's closing satisfaction with this. Facilitate discussion on whether this is Hume's real view, an ironic performance, or a strategic softening given the religious censorship of his era.

Closure

7 min

Students write a quick response identifying which character's argument held up best under the class's own scrutiny, citing one specific line or idea from the reading as evidence.

Discussion Questions

- 1 Is the analogy between the universe and a designed machine strong enough to license an inference to an intelligent designer, or does Philo show that the two things being compared are too dissimilar?
- 2 If the world's imperfections — suffering, waste, disorder — are real, what does that suggest about the character of any inferred designer, and does it push toward polytheism, a limited deity, or no clear conclusion at all?
- 3 Why does Hume use a three-voiced dialogue instead of a straightforward essay — what does that form let him do that a single authorial voice couldn't?
- 4 Is Philo's concession in Part XII a genuine change of mind, an ironic performance, or something else — what textual evidence supports your reading?
- 5 Does Demea's suspicion of reasoning about God, favoring humility and revelation instead, offer a more defensible position than Cleanthes's confident empirical theology, even though Demea is the one who storms out of the conversation?

Assessment

Students select one of Philo's objections to the design argument discussed in class and write a short essay explaining it in their own words, testing it against a modern example of "apparent design," and stating whether the objection still holds against that modern example. Grade on faithful representation of Philo's actual reasoning and clear application to the chosen case.

Extension Activity

Assign students to read the full text of Part XII (freely available via the Gutenberg link) and write a one-page reading response arguing for their own interpretation of Philo's final concession — sincere shift, ironic performance, or strategic self-protection — using specific lines as evidence.

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